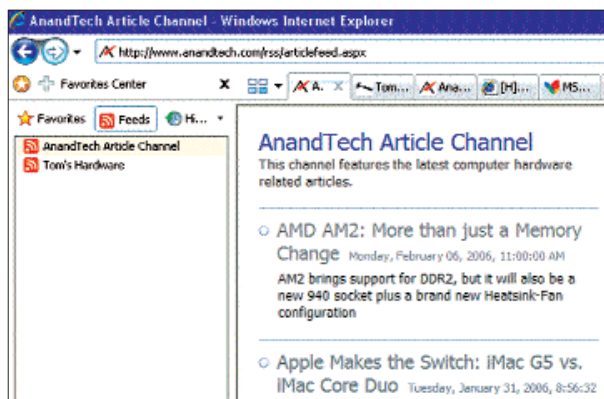


RSS Feeds

Yes, IE7 integrates an RSS feed reader! Situated under Favorites, the "Feeds" button converts IE7 into a full-fledged feed reader. Any site with an auto-discoverable feed—in the RSS or ATOM format—lights up the orange "Feeds" icon. Clicking the button opens the feed in a browser window. Clicking the [+] icon will subscribe you to the feed. The "Favorites" centre has also been redesigned to improve usability. A small white star in a yellow circle represents the Favorites menu; it can also be docked as a panel for anytime access. We found the feed-reading tool to be one of the best we have seen thus



The integrated Feed Reader in IE7

far. Moreover, IE7 also supports the OPML (Outline Processor Markup Language) format, which makes importing and exporting feeds quite easy between standard feed-reading applications.

Speed

To be honest, we didn't find the Public Preview of IE7 to be any faster than IE6. However, considering that it's a beta, we'll give it some leeway.

In Sum

In terms of features, IE7 is just catching up with its competitors—most of the new features were implemented on other browsers a long time ago—but it has done a decent job of the features themselves, and of enhanced security.

It is not fair to pass judgement on this Public Preview of IE 7, since many more features are expected in the final version. However, one thing is for sure: Internet Explorer 7 is a huge step on Microsoft's part to ring out the old.



Thumbnails of Web sites appear when you roll your mouse over the tab

OPERA

Opera is an independent browser company that's been in the business for a long time now. Since their core competency is browsers, innovation has been the only way to grow, and they've therefore always been ahead of the rest. In fact, a lot of the features seen today in most browsers, such as mouse gestures and tabbed browsing, were first introduced by Opera.

Opera 8.5 is the current version of the browser available for free download. As you might expect, it has most of the features one would want in a browser: a feed reader, mail client, notes, panels, and more. Apart from features, the browser offers a lot of customisation options for the geeky.

The second beta preview for Opera 9 was out when we decided to do this round-up. So instead of taking you through the features of version 8.5, we opted to take a look at some fascinating features that the new version has brought in.

Look And Feel

Opera has chosen to keep the look and feel similar to the older version, and the familiar tabs, panels and toolbars make you feel at home. It's no surprise that of all the browsers, Opera implements tabbed browsing best. Each tab has a small close button of its own, something Firefox doesn't have, and IE7 has "borrowed." You can rearrange tabs just by dragging them, and dragging a tab to the personal bar turns it into a bookmark. One good addition to Opera 9 is the thumbnail view of a site

when you hover your mouse over its tab. Another common complaint that people had was that the browser would open without an open tab—this has been fixed, and now Opera will always have a blank page open even after you close all tabs.

Similarly, Opera 9 also retains Panels, which are nothing but windows that allow for easy navigation to data such as Notes, browser history, all links on a particular page, and more. A customisation option is also available for Panels—you can download additional Panels from the Opera community Web site.

Customisation

Tech enthusiasts prefer Opera because of the high level of customisation that's possible.



Cool widgets in Opera 9!

While most browsers only allow customisation of certain critical features, Opera lets you customise almost everything, including its look—it's completely skinnable.

Opera 9 has taken a leaf out of Apple's book, and now offers "Widgets"—small applications that run outside the browser window and perform small tasks such as showing you the time and date, or getting stock quotes from a particular Web site.